What makes me *happy*



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

TIPS FOR HAPPINESS

STAY IN THE MOMENT: Ninety-five per cent of what we call happiness can be achieved by just sitting for some time every day and focusing on the present. Make it a daily practice, something you can't do without, like eating food and drinking water. It is crucial to happiness.



APOORVA LOCHAN
Mindfulness guru, life coach and mentor

EXERCISE: Your regular exercise routine should include workouts that promote flexibility, strength and cardio. A combination of these three keeps you in a high state where you are full of energy. One without the other doesn't have the same impact.

LIVE ETHICALLY: Happiness is impossible to experience in a sustainable manner if one does not live ethically.

DROP THE 'IF ONLY': The phrase or thought can make you miserable. Accept events as they unfold and you will be happy. A lack of 'acceptance' is one of the major causes of depression.

SPREAD MAITRI: Feel and send out feelings of goodwill, forgiveness, compassion and an assurance of harmlessness out into the universe. The Laws of Nature always send these back to you. When you do it with real intent, you will experience joy while doing it. It brings a tangible sense of bliss.

COMPASSION AND FORGIVENESS: Ayurveda emphasises that the cause of all ailments lies in the mind. Have compassion for every living being, including yourself, and especially for those who hurt you. Holding on to grudges or anger causes toxicity and, over time, we end up with chronic ailments.

GRATITUDE: An attitude of gratitude should be the first emotion in the morning and the last feeling at night. Don't chase the mirage of a pot of gold somewhere in the future.

-as told to Aditi Pai

The programme includes a curriculum, an app and training for school teachers. Jaswant Kaur, 55, at a Brihanmumbai Municipal School, is one of those who benefitted immensely from the training programme. Her formal education ended after Class 10, but she has now brushed up on her grammar and class management techniques through the training. Kaur says the children now enjoy the classes a lot more and she is referred to as an *angrez* on family WhatsApp groups as she responds in English.

Another teacher, Amina Shaikh, 52, says she improved her fluency in the language and is thankful that the programme was a "safe space with no judgements". She has been devouring articles on the Pehlay Akshar app—'Stay hungry, stay foolish' is her favourite quote. "The training modules try to understand the difficulties of the teachers who are not confident about speaking English. All teachers in Marathi and Hindi medium schools should adopt this programme," says Kiwade Patil, the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) education inspector.

The programme's DIKSHA App has about 500 lessons, and there is also a collaboration with SCERT Maharashtra to televise 'English classrooms' across Maharashtra on DD Sahyadri. Goenka's aim is to now take the programme beyond Mumbai to rural areas in Maharashtra. Celebrities like Sunil Gavaskar and Sonakshi Sinha have volunteered to lend their voice to the 'A story a day' programme that started at the onset of the lockdown in 2020. So far, according to the company, the Pehlay Akshar program has reached 200,000 students, trained 7,000 teachers and is present in three states. It continues to be self-funded.

The students, too, have a new-found confidence. Vinayak Soni, an eighth standard student at Worli Sea Face school, says "speaking English is a big respect for me, I only speak in English when I am in class". He wants to become a software engineer. Vrudant, a 9th standard student at a BMC school in Mumbai, has enjoyed learning the language with the help of flash cards. He says he loves watching documentaries in English, *Man vs Wild* is an all-time favourite. His ambition is to become a pilot. And for that, he believes knowing English would be a big help. Call it a colonial hangover but fluency in the language continues to be associated with aspiration, ambition and a window to a bigger and better world. The Pehlay Akshar program is tapping into that inherent need "to be respected", as Soni puts it. ■

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